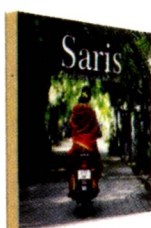


Eternal Drapes of INDIA

A majestic volume celebrates the classicism of saris—and tells you how to wear them



SARIS: TRADITION AND BEYOND

by RTA KAPUR CHISHTI

General Editor

MARTAND SINGH

Roli

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| By Malvika Singh |

Unstitched lengths of textured fabrics, silk, cotton, silk and cotton, some with fine woven patterns of floral and geometric motifs of animals and jungle scenes, others with stripes and checks or just plain, embellished with contrasting colours from a rich palette of vegetable dyes with their very special patina, in varying lengths that define where they were woven—the great, pure saris of India live on in a world where natural fibres have been replaced by inorganic man-made nylons and polyesters. The extraordinary length of cloth, the sari, has withstood the standardisation of dress styles that are cut to rigid, often unflattering forms and

shapes, sizes and lengths with zips and buttons, all of which have, in recent decades, invaded the domain of our traditionally languid and flowing, feminine and refined, tried and tested traditional forms of draping sensuous and delicious fabrics around our bodies. Like swarms of locusts, these outfits have attempted to assault and attack the natural and organic, comfortable and versatile sari which has fortunately survived the onslaught and is going through a renewal with the restoration and revival of many fine and complicated weaving techniques that had begun to fade away.

It is an age where corporate women in India, cloning their Western counterparts, think it is fashionable to wear suits to work, oblivious that the trouser and coat makes them look like a